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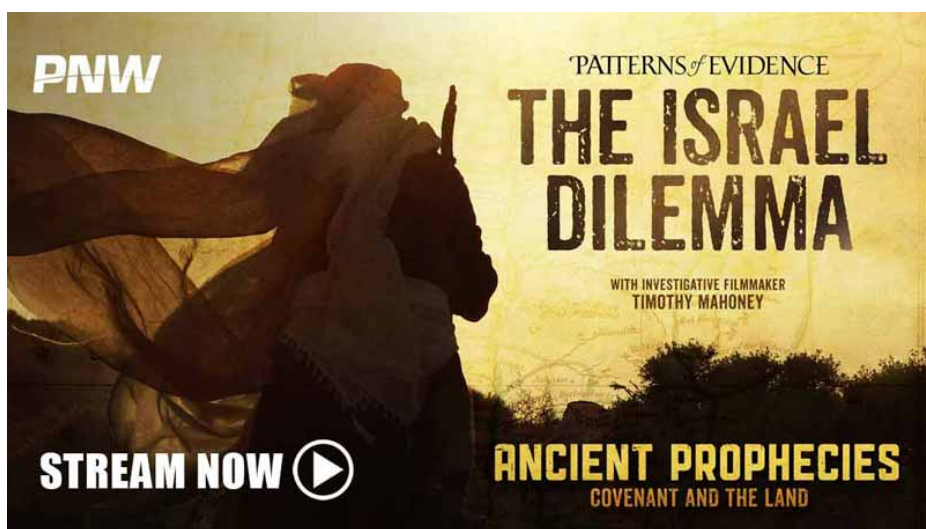
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ARTICLE

The Most Ridiculous Church Debate Of The Year





BY PNW STAFF JULY 09, 2026

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For years we've been told there are certain issues that are simply too controversial to decide.

So what do organizations do?

They create a committee.

Study it.

Delay it.

Hope the controversy cools off before anyone has to take a position.

That's exactly what happened this week.

The only problem?

The organization wasn't a Fortune 500 company trying to navigate corporate politics.

It wasn't Congress trying to avoid a difficult vote.

It was a Christian denomination trying to decide whether its pastors should be... monogamous.

Yes, you read that correctly.

The Presbyterian Church (USA) postponed debate over a proposal that would explicitly require its clergy to be monogamous, referring the matter to committee after the issue generated significant disagreement among delegates. Let that sink in for a moment. A church couldn't decide whether those entrusted with preaching God's Word should be expected to remain sexually faithful to one spouse.



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How did we arrive at a place where one of Christianity's oldest and most basic moral standards has become too controversial to affirm?

The proposal itself should have been anything but groundbreaking. It sought to reaffirm what Christians have understood for centuries--that those called to lead Christ's Church should model biblical standards in both doctrine and personal conduct. Yet even that proved too much for many within the denomination, particularly those who argued such language would exclude or stigmatize people in alternative relationship arrangements, including polyamorous relationships.

Rather than settle the issue, the denomination chose a familiar institutional escape hatch: send it to committee.

Anyone who has watched politics knows the strategy well. When leaders don't want to make a difficult decision--or fear upsetting influential factions--they study it. They appoint a task force. They refer it for further consideration. Sometimes committees are valuable. Other times they simply become a place where difficult truths are parked until a future meeting.

Unfortunately, that appears to be what happened here.

The deeper concern isn't merely the delay itself. It is what the delay reveals.

Consider what is actually being debated.

It isn't an argument about worship music or church budgets.

The controversy is whether pastors should be expected to practice monogamy.



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Fifty years ago, no Christian would have imagined that question needing a committee.

Scripture certainly doesn't treat it as controversial.

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When outlining the qualifications for elders and overseers, the Apostle Paul describes church leaders as being "the husband of one wife," managing their households well and living lives worthy of imitation. Throughout both the Old and New Testaments, God's design for marriage is consistently presented as an exclusive covenant marked by lifelong faithfulness.

Those standards were never viewed as oppressive limitations. They were evidence of spiritual maturity.

But increasingly within parts of the modern church, biblical standards are no longer measured by whether they are faithful to Scripture. They are measured by whether they align with contemporary cultural values.

That is a profound shift.

The question quietly changes from, "What does God require?" to "Who might feel excluded?"

Of course, Christians are called to love every person. Every church should welcome people seeking Christ regardless of their past, their struggles, or the sins that have marked their lives. The Gospel is for everyone.

But welcoming sinners is not the same thing as redefining the qualifications for spiritual leadership.

Grace never requires compromising truth.

History shows that theological drift rarely happens overnight. It moves incrementally. One accommodation becomes the justification for another. Teachings that were once unquestioned become optional. Eventually, convictions once considered foundational are portrayed as intolerant.

The Presbyterian Church (USA) has followed that pattern for years, revising longstanding positions on sexuality and marriage while continuing to experience declining membership. Rather than asking whether accommodation to the culture has strengthened the church, many appear determined to continue down the same road.

The irony is difficult to miss.

The culture promises relevance through compromise, yet every compromise seems to create another demand for further change. The finish line never stays in the same place.

Today's debate over monogamy would have shocked previous generations of Christians. One can't help but wonder what tomorrow's "too controversial" biblical teaching will be.

This story ultimately isn't about polyamory.

It isn't even about one denomination.

It is about whether the Church will continue to believe that Scripture speaks with authority even when its teachings collide with the spirit of the age.

Because if a church can no longer confidently say that its pastors should be faithful to one spouse without referring the question to committee, then the greatest controversy isn't over marriage.

It's over whether God's Word still has the final say.





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